

A full-page photograph of a person rock climbing a steep, textured cliff face. The climber is positioned in the lower-middle section of the frame, wearing a blue t-shirt, dark pants, and a climbing harness. They are reaching up with their right arm towards a rock overhang. A green rope is visible extending from the climber down towards the bottom right. The rock face is composed of various shades of tan, orange, and white, with some darker patches and small green plants growing in crevices. The overall scene is a high-angle shot looking down at the climber.

CHAPTER 8

DETAILED PROGRAM DESIGN

PHOTO: JULIE ELLISON

As I wrote earlier, the program must be flexible. Research shows us that athletes who continually fail to hit performance goals, such as sticking to a too-rigid plan, lose motivation. What I want most for you is to have a successful training season, and then come back for more. In this section, I want to review the programs, and give you a detailed look at how this will work in the real world.

The important thing to remember is that there is no particular magic in the sessions I have outlined in the book - they are simply formats I've used successfully in my own climbing and in the programs of my athletes. The critical aspect of the programs is that you try to develop the proper energy systems at the proper times. In block cycles, this means one focus and a lot of maintenance. In nonlinear programs, this means changing session formats every time, even if you don't feel like it. If you prefer more campusing and less bouldering, go for it. If you would rather stay away from the weights and just use the hangboard, great. These programs will work as long as you follow the principles - regardless of your chosen methods.

If the programs were more rigid, this chapter would have to be extensive. As it is, the nonlinear plans are so flexible that they need little detail. The biggest issue I've met with such programs is that some athletes feel the need for more restrictions! Let me put forth a couple of examples to show you how the programs work.

The block programming templates are more restrictive, but the 2-focus sessions paired with one maintenance session is a solid rule.

NONLINEAR PROGRAM

4-WEEK - GENERAL

(EXAMPLE 1)

In this program, we'll follow the Level I plan of 3 session types per cycle. This is by far the most useful and flexible program for most climbers. In this example, we look at a climber who is climbing on a regular weekend-only schedule:

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THU.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Strength	Power		Endurance		Climb Outside	Climb Outside
Week 2		Strength		Power		Climb Outside	Climb Outside
Week 3		Endurance		Strength		Climb Outside	
Week 4	Power	Endurance		Strength		Climb Outside	Climb Outside

Note that the climber is simply cycling through the three training session types during his weekday training program. As is the case with most of us, this climber can only train on certain days of the week (Mondays, Tuesdays, and Thursdays). After a hard Sunday, a rest day is occasionally needed on Monday. Also, she takes a Friday rest day each week so that her training doesn't negatively affect her performance on Saturday.

For all intents and purposes, the training is held separate from the climbing. It is hard to tailor a climbing day to fit the training

plan, so we simply organize the “practice” and “performance” separately, as they do in the majority of other sports. Over the course of completing a redpoint pyramid, a climber will normally do a little less training volume during the week as the intensity of the performances increases. This is normal, and such a schedule for a 12a pyramid might look like this:

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THU.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Strength	Power		Endurance		RP Pyramid, (1x11b, final RP of T4)	RP Pyramid, (1x11c, 1st RP of T3)
Week 2		Strength		Power		RP Pyramid, (2x11c, 2nd, 3rd RP of T3)	Volume Day, 8 RP 10b-11a
Week 3			Endurance			RP Pyramid, (1x11d, 1st RP of T2)	
Week 4	Strength		Power			RP Pyramid, (1x11d, 2nd RP of T2)	RP Pyramid, (2x good attempts at 12a)

Again, I’ll emphasize that the training progression should work separately from, and in support of, the climbing cycle. We must not fall into the trap of “more is better.” Better is better.

The above discussion gives you a general look into what a cycle might look like. The next section will give a more detailed look at a training month, showing not only each day’s planned workouts, but the progressions of those workouts. By looking at what is going on more intimately, you can see why we naturally tend to train less frequently as we approach the peak of a pyramid.

NONLINEAR PROGRAM

6-WEEK - DETAILED

(EXAMPLE 2)

The example below is a 3-session nonlinear cycle, like the one above, but with session details. What I want to underscore here is that although the cycle naturally progresses toward fewer sessions each week, the intensity increases in each session. Early in the cycle, most climbers can train two days in a row, or at least every other day. As the training (and redpointing) gets harder, two days between training sessions becomes the norm. Despite fewer training days, fitness does not decline.

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THU.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Integrated Strength (60 min)	Boulder / Campus (90 min)		EE Interval Combinations (60 min)	Integrated Strength (60 min)		Climb Outside - RP Pyramid
Week 2		Boulder / Campus (90 min)	EE Interval Combinations (60 min)		Integrated Strength (60 min)	Climb Outside - RP Pyramid	Climb Outside - Volume
Week 3		Boulder / Campus (90 min)	EE Interval Combinations (70 min)		Integrated Strength (60 min)	Climb Outside - RP Pyramid	
Week 4	Boulder / Campus (90 min)		EE Interval Combinations (70 min)		Integrated Strength (60 min)		Climb Outside - RP Pyramid
Week 5		Boulder / Campus (90 min)			EE Interval Combinations (80 min)	Climb Outside - RP Pyramid	
Week 6	Integrated Strength (60 minutes)			Boulder / Campus (90 min)			Climb Outside - RP Pyramid



PHOTO: MATT PINCUS

NONLINEAR PROGRAM

4-WEEK - IN-SEASON

REDPOINT PHASE (EXAMPLE 3)

Training in-season not only can enhance performance, it can extend to length of your performance phase. The big key is to make sure that your training remains in a supporting role. All of your hardest efforts must go into redpointing, and you will want to **cease advancing the intensity of your sessions when you are at the peak of the pyramid**. We avoid placing any training before climbing days, and only train the day after climbing if the athlete feels recovered and ready for a quality session.

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THU.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Strength		RP Pyramid, (1x12c, final RP of T2)	Endurance		RP Pyramid, (1x12d, first attempts of T1)	
Week 2	Power		RP Pyramid, (1x12d, first RP of T1)		Strength	RP Pyramid, (1x12d, second attempts on T1)	
Week 3	Endurance		RP Pyramid, (1x12d, second attempts on T1)		Power	RP Pyramid, (1x12d, second RP of T1)	
Week 4		Strength		Endurance		RP Pyramid, (1x12d, third RP of T1)	

NONLINEAR PROGRAM

4-WEEK WINTER / OFF SEASON PHASE

(EXAMPLE 4)

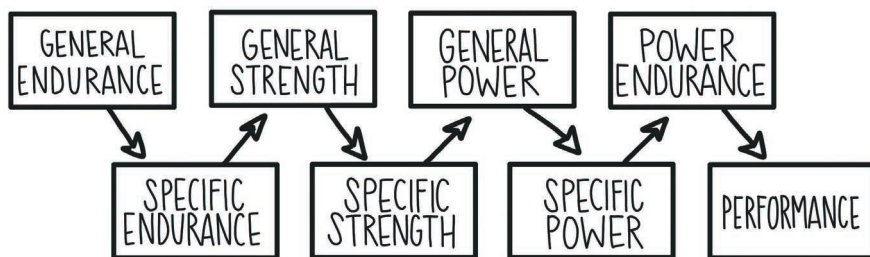
The example below is a strict, training-only schedule for an athlete that can train 4 days per week. The cycle is followed in sequence, but the load on the climber varies based on where the training days fall in relation to rest days. There is no reason to adhere blindly to a strict schedule, and you'll often see that even a planned program such as this will occasionally feature just three training days on a 4-day training week.

Once again, the critical thing to watch is that you are progressing in each of the sessions as the training cycle passes. If you are plateaued or feeling tired, it's probably a factor of too much training. Part of the beauty of this program is you can adjust it at the snap of a finger, and often get right back on track.

	MON.	TUE.	WED.	THU.	FRI.	SAT.	SUN.
Week 1	Strength	Power		Endurance	Strength		
Week 2	Power	Endurance		Strength	Power		
Week 3	Endurance	Strength		Power	Endurance		
Week 4	Strength	Power		Endurance	Strength		

STANDARD BLOCK PROGRAM (EXAMPLE 5)

There are many ways to build programs using the blocks, but there is one way that is most effective for most people. If your goal is very specific, such as getting in shape for a particular 14-move bouldery route, your training can reflect that...you build blocks that focus on the strength and energy needs of that one thing. However, if your goal is to build your overall fitness and “climbing base” for sending a variety of limit-level routes, the progression below makes the most sense.



With this structure, you get a full 8 weeks to focus on one fitness quality - always moving from general to specific - before moving on to the next focus. You move toward qualities that are more specific to hard climbing late in the cycle (power and power endurance). In all, this is a decent structure for most climbers. But what about my year? How does this fit within a 12-month period?

It doesn't. This structure would be a long-term aim at a 4-8 week performance phase for a major competition or a trip. In a year's framework, you might aim to peak a couple of times. Remembering that there are thirteen 4-week cycles per year, I

try to be sure that an athlete does at least one phase of general training in each system, then can repeat most-needed training as the season progresses.

Critically, we also need to program in some recovery weeks. I think most of us need at least 4 per year, which can be taken all together (harder to build back from) or in two 2-week blocks, which are reasonably easy to restart from. Thus a year might look like this:

MONTH	WEEKS	PHASE
January	1-4	GE
February	5-8	SE
March	9-12	GS
April	13-16	SS
May	17-20	GP
	21-24	SP
June	25-28	PE
July	29-32	Performance
August	33-34	Recovery
September	35-38	GE
October	39-42	SE
	43-46	PE
November	47-50	Performance
December	51-52	Recovery

Over time, most athletes find that certain blocks of training don't need to be included as often. For example, a person with very good general endurance who doesn't ever tap out that system, might only visit it once per year. For many bouldering-focused climbers, this should be the case (less endurance, not *no*

endurance.) Likewise, a sport climber or a big wall climber might have more endurance blocks in their program. These choices should be based both on upcoming goals and testing of limiters.

If this long-term plan seems restrictive or makes you anxious about your ability to have a flexible schedule, I have a solution for you: don't do it. Doing a poor job of following this program will not produce good results for you. You are much better off on a nonlinear program as noted above.

LONG-SEASON BLOCK PROGRAM (EXAMPLE 6)

This block phase is specifically aimed at climbers who have a 3-4 month time of the year where there is not much climbing to be had outside, or those who have a long comp season with just a few months prep in-between seasons.

Assuming there is a performance phase in the fall (October, in this example), a year plan for a route climber looking at sustained performance for a long period might follow:

WEEKS	FOCUS	SEASON
1-4 (starting November)	General Endurance	Off
5-8	General Strength	Off
9-12	Specific Strength	Off
13-16	General Power	Off
17-20	Specific Power	Off
21-24	Specific Endurance	Off
25-28	Power Endurance	On
29-32	Performance	On
33-34	Recovery	On
36-40	Specific Power	On
41-44	Performance	On
45-48	Power Endurance	On
49-52	Performance	On

ENDURANCE-BUILDING BLOCK PROGRAM (EXAMPLE 7)

Sometimes we need more time to develop new levels of a particular area of our climbing fitness. The more experienced you become, the longer this might take. For route climbers getting ready for a long road trip or a vacation to a sport climbing mecca, a focus on developing new levels of endurance can be rewarding. Endurance sits on a foundation of strength and power. We need to lay these foundations down several months before our trip, and then maintain them as best we can through a long season of energy system work.

The key feature of this program is that we build specific endurance, switch to honing our power endurance, and then switch back to specific endurance again. By doing this, we ask the body to continue to stimulate big changes in the muscles that will have more permanence than a simple 4-8 week cycle could. If you can get to where you can hold strength and power levels high, you could conceivably do another full 8 weeks of general and specific endurance work before going back to focus on strength. I recommend this for climbers who lack the ability to sustain several hard tries on a climb in a day, or simply pump out on overhanging terrain that is within their normal redpoint range in other styles.

WEEKS	FOCUS
1-4	General Endurance
5-8	General Strength
9-12	General Power
13-16	Specific Power
17-20	Specific Endurance
21-24	Power Endurance
25-28	Specific Endurance
29-32	Power Endurance
33-36 (up to 38)	Performance